

Streamline moderne

Streamline moderne (also called art moderne) originated in the functional aesthetic of the Bauhaus, and rose to popularity in the 1930s, particularly in the US. It was in part a less decorative outgrowth of art deco, but was also a product of its time, fusing the pared-down austerity of the Depression with the efficiency, dynamism and speed embodied in the new machine age. Technological advances, smooth and powerful machines, high-speed transportation and innovative construction methods all filtered into the style, which went on show at the 1933 World Fair in Chicago and permeated all areas of design, from trains to toasters. Streamline moderne buildings have an aerodynamic look: rounded corners, often wrapped with strong horizontals and long bands of windows; ocean liner-type balconies; porthole windows. Eschewing the bright colours sometimes seen in art deco, most streamline moderne buildings have smooth white-plastered exteriors. Robert V. Derrah's (1894–1946) Coca-Cola Building in Los Angeles (1939) resembles an ocean liner, set off with minimal red branding.



Hotel Normandie, Puerto Rico, Félix Benítez Rexach, 1938–42